Introduction

Community forestry

Community forest management (CFM) has emerged over the past five decades as a dominant paradigm in forest governance, grounded in the recognition that local communities — as the *de facto* managers over large areas of the world's forests — are best placed to sustainably manage the resources on which they depend. At its core, CFM involves the formal transfer of management authority and resource use rights from state institutions to local communities, alongside recognition of their right to benefit from forest resources (Charnley and Poe 2007; FAO 1978). Although early programmes in the 1970s and 1980s focused narrowly on fuelwood supply and tree planting in South Asia and the Sahel, CFM has since evolved into a broad and diverse set of approaches — including participatory forest management, joint forest management, and community-based forest management — implemented across Asia, Africa, Latin America and Europe (Roberts and Gautam 2003; Baynes et al. 2015; Gilmour 2016).

The rationale for CFM rests on the premise that local communities, with vested interests in maintaining forest resource flows and access to place- and time-specific knowledge, can govern forests more effectively and sustainably than centralised state institutions (Hajjar et al. 2021). Where well-implemented, CFM has delivered substantive benefits: forest regeneration (by as much as 37% in Nepal), reduced deforestation, enhanced biodiversity conservation, improved rural livelihoods and incomes, and stronger local institutions and community cohesion (Gilmour 2016; Charnley and Poe 2007; Baynes et al. 2015). Community forestry also positions local communities to participate in emerging carbon, biodiversity and ecosystem service markets, offering new revenue streams for forest protection.

Nevertheless, the outcomes of CFM globally have been mixed (Roberts and Gautam 2003). Recurring challenges include weak institutional capacity, insecure land tenure, unclear forest boundaries and competing resource claims, inequitable benefit-sharing arrangements, limited social capital, governance capacity and business acumen among local communities, poor market access, and high certification costs for timber and non-timber forest products (NTFPs) (Wily 2004; McDermott and Schreckenberg 2009). The conditions most conducive to CFM success include strong government facilitation, a sound legal framework devolving management and user rights to communities, high social capital, sustained support from Non-government organisations (NGOs) or private partners, effective rule enforcement, and the development of viable forest enterprises (Pagdee, Kim, and Daugherty 2006; Blomley 2013; Baynes et al. 2015). Where one or more of these conditions are absent, communities may be formally enrolled in CFM programmes without gaining meaningful authority or tangible benefits.

Community forestry in Zambia

In Zambia, the trajectory of CFM reflects a gradual transition across four generations of interventions (1980–2025), from early awareness campaigns and tree-planting initiatives to the large-scale adoption of formal community forest groups driven by REDD+ and carbon finance mechanisms (Moombe, Malesu, and Harrison 2025). The context for CFM in Zambia is shaped by a distinctive land tenure situation: approximately 94% of land is under customary ownership (Sichone 2008) and significant land-use decisions have historically resided with traditional chiefs. CFM in Zambia, therefore, involves devolution of authority not only from the state but also to some extent from traditional leadership structures, and has been driven as much by the need to transition to sustainable forest management (SFM) and enable communities to generate localised benefits, as by concerns over tenure security or management authority *per se*.

The legal and policy framework for CFM in Zambia is now well-established. The Forests Act No. 4 of 2015 and the Forests (Community Forest Management) Regulations (SI No. 11 of 2018) provide the principal legal basis for CFM, granting communities the right to apply for recognition as community forest management groups (CFMGs), prepare and implement management plans, and access forest user rights including rights to timber and carbon credits. However, Zambia is also losing forests at a rate of 250,000 to 300,000 hectares annually, alongside substantial carbon losses from forest degradation, making improved forest governance a national priority aligned with the country's nationally determined contributions (NDCs) under the Paris Agreement.

Since the formal CFM framework came into effect, the sector has expanded rapidly. The carbon market in particular has accelerated the adoption of CFM in Zambia, offering a vehicle for partnerships between carbon trading companies, conservation NGOs, and local communities that benefit from forest protection (Moombe, Malesu, and Harrison 2025). As of March 2025, there were 351 CFMGs in Zambia, presiding over approximately 9.4 million hectares of community forests (CFs) across all ten provinces (Moombe, Malesu, and Harrison 2025). North-western Province has the largest area under CFM and Luapula the smallest. Despite this growth, implementation quality varies considerably. Documented challenges include inadequate exit strategies by supporting projects, inconsistent monitoring and follow-up support, low capacity in business and governance skills among CFMGs, insufficient funding to complete the formal establishment process, lack of clarity over benefit-sharing arrangements, poor representation of women despite their high dependence on NTFPs, and unresolved intra-community conflicts over land and resources (Moombe and Kaumba 2022; Lundu 2023).

Aims of this study

With CFM expanding rapidly in Zambia, the Government of Zambia, donors, and other stakeholders have recognised a critical need to understand whether CFM is achieving its intended outcomes of improved SFM and sustainable development, and where improvements in CFM implementation are required. This study was designed to fill that knowledge gap. Specifically, the study aimed to: (i) assess whether CFM in Zambia has led to improved sustainable management of forests and other natural resources; (ii) understand whether CFM has contributed to sustainable development; (iii) identify opportunities for improved implementation of CFM, including through enhanced monitoring of outcomes; and (iv) generate policy recommendations for improved CFM implementation in Zambia.

To address these aims, we surveyed 75 CFMGs across eight provinces, combining focus group discussions (FGDs) with CFMG executives, female, male and youth community members, and individual interviews with key stakeholders, namely community members, traditional leaders, District Forestry Officers (DFOs), and NGO representatives. We examine CFM performance across four domains — governance, sustainable forest management, economic transformation, and equity and inclusion — and identify the factors associated with stronger or weaker outcomes across these domains.

The report is organised as follows. The **Survey Overview** chapter describes the sample of community forests and interviewees. It demonstrates that the sample is sufficiently representative to support national-level inference. The **Governance** chapter examines whether CFMGs have completed the required legal and administrative processes, established functional governance structures, and developed business plans. The **Sustainable Forest Management** chapter assesses the impacts of CFM on deforestation, charcoal production, fire frequency, wildlife, and natural resource management. The **Economic Transformation** chapter evaluates changes in access to forest resources, employment, income, and the realisation of carbon and other economic opportunities. The **Equity and Inclusion** chapter examines benefit sharing, gender equity, transparency, and the impacts of CFM on poverty. The **Discussion** chapter synthesises findings across all four domains and draws out the key messages for CFM policy and practice in Zambia. The **Recommendations** chapter translates these findings into concrete, actionable recommendations for government, NGOs, and carbon trading enterprises. Three appendices provide supporting material: **Appendix I** describes the methods in detail; **Appendix II** contains the full survey tool used in the FGDs and individual interviews; and **Appendix III** lists the 75 community forests surveyed.

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